Supplementary Material B

Six-Axis Jazz Evaluation Rubric with Anchored Descriptors

Supplementary material accompanying "Can AI Swing? A Musician-Centred Evaluation of Jazz Competence in Audio Generation Models." This file contains the full anchored rubric referenced in Section 3.3 of the manuscript.

Each piece is rated 1–5 on six axes. Scores are integers. Half-scores are not used; when in doubt, round down. Total score = sum of six axes (maximum 30).

Axis 1: Harmonic Authenticity

Does the piece use jazz harmony convincingly — extended chords, functional progressions, idiomatic voice leading?

Score	Descriptor	Concrete Anchor
1	No jazz harmony	Triads or power chords throughout. Sounds like pop or folk with a jazz label. Example: C–F–G–C repeated under a saxophone timbre.
2	Superficial jazz markers	Some 7th chords present but used as colour, not function. Progressions don't resolve logically. Example: Cmaj7–Fmaj7–Gmaj7 with no ii–V–I or tonal motion.
3	Surface-plausible but flawed	ii–V–I present and resolves, but voice leading is clunky, extensions clash, or alterations are avoided entirely. Sounds like jazz played by someone who learned chord names but not how they move. Example: Dm7–G7–Cmaj7 with parallel octaves and no chordal colour.
4	Convincing jazz harmony with minor lapses	Strong functional harmony, extensions used idiomatically, occasional awkward substitution or resolution. A working jazz musician would approve of most of it.
5	Idiomatic and inventive	Tritone substitutions, modal interchange, altered dominants used correctly and musically. Voice leading is smooth. Sounds like a competent jazz composer wrote this. Example: Db7 substituting G7 in a ii–V–I, resolving to Cmaj9 with the b9 resolving correctly.

Axis 2: Swing Feel and Microtiming

Does the piece actually swing? This is the single hardest thing to fake — swing is a specific microtiming relationship between long and short eighth notes, plus a particular placement of accents.

Score	Descriptor	Concrete Anchor
1	Completely straight	All eighth notes equal length. Sounds mechanical or like a metronome. No swing whatsoever.
2	Attempted swing, fails	There is rhythmic variation but it doesn't cohere into swing feel. Might sound like uneven quantisation rather than intentional lilt.
3	Weak or inconsistent swing	Swing ratio present in parts but inconsistent across the piece. Feels like a MIDI sequence with swing quantisation applied — technically there but unconvincing. Example: drums swing but melody plays straight.
4	Clear swing feel with minor inconsistencies	The piece swings recognisably; a jazz musician would tap their foot. One or two passages lose it or feel stiff.
5	Natural, idiomatic swing	The long-short ratio feels organic, not quantised. Accents fall on 2 and 4

Score	Descriptor	Concrete Anchor
		in the drums. The melody lays back appropriately. Comparable to hearing a human jazz ensemble.

Axis 3: Improvisational Coherence

Does the improvised content (solos, fills, melodic development) exhibit musical logic — motivic development, call-and-response, tension and release — or is it a random sequence of jazz-sounding notes?

Score	Descriptor	Concrete Anchor
1	Incoherent	Notes chosen seem random within a scale. No melodic logic, no phrases, no sense of direction. Sounds like a drunk person playing scales.
2	Phrases exist but don't connect	Some phrase-shaped gestures, but they don't relate to each other. No motivic development. Sounds like random licks stitched together.
3	Surface coherence, no depth	Phrases begin and end cleanly; the line sounds like jazz. But there's no motivic development — nothing comes back, nothing is developed. A statistically plausible solo.
4	Clear motivic logic	A motif introduced early recurs or develops later. Tension builds across phrases. Call-and-response between instruments. A listener would feel the line is going somewhere.
5	Excellent improvisational narrative	The solo tells a story: exposition, development, climax, resolution. Motivic transformation, rhythmic displacement, clear peak moment. Comparable to a well-constructed Parker or Rollins solo.

Axis 4: Idiomatic Jazz Vocabulary

Are the sounds, articulations, timbres, and performance gestures recognisably jazz? This covers: swing articulation (ghost notes, slides, fall-offs), typical jazz instrumentation, correct idiomatic roles for each instrument.

Score	Descriptor	Concrete Anchor
1	No jazz vocabulary	Could be any genre. Generic instrumentation. No jazz-specific articulation. Example: piano solo with no comping, no walking bass, drums playing a rock beat.
2	Jazz instrumentation, wrong roles	The right instruments are present (piano, bass, drums, horn) but they behave incorrectly. Bass plays sustained notes instead of walking; piano plays full chords in the left hand instead of voicing.
3	Mostly correct roles, vocabulary thin	Instruments in correct roles, but jazz-specific articulations are generic or absent. Sounds like jazz played by classical musicians — correct but sterile.
4	Strong vocabulary with occasional lapses	Ghost notes, fall-offs, ride cymbal pattern, walking bass all present. One instrument or passage is out of idiom.
5	Fully idiomatic	Every instrument sounds like it was played by a jazz musician. Comping is sparse and reactive. Bass walks with correct chord tones on beats 1 and 3. Drummer plays the ride cymbal pattern and drops bombs. Horns use jazz articulation (shakes, bends, vibrato).

Axis 5: Ensemble Interaction

Do the instruments respond to each other, or are they playing their own parts independently without listening? Real jazz is a conversation.

Score	Descriptor	Concrete Anchor
1	No interaction	Each instrument plays a fixed part with no relation to the others. Could have been recorded in separate rooms from different songs.
2	Minimal awareness	Parts are compatible but independent. Occasional rhythmic alignment by coincidence.
3	Functional ensemble	Parts fit together competently. No obvious clashes. But the instruments don't respond to each other — piano comps the same way regardless of what the soloist does.
4	Reactive playing evident	Comping changes density around the soloist's phrases. Drums set up arrivals or respond to climaxes. Not consistent but clearly present.
5	Genuine conversation	Drummer drops a bomb under a high phrase. Pianist lays out when the soloist is busy. Call-and-response between instruments. Fills in the gaps, not over the melody. Comparable to listening to a real jazz trio react in the moment.

Axis 6: Formal Structure

Does the piece have a recognisable jazz form — head/solos/head, 12-bar blues cycles, AABA — or is it formless?

Score	Descriptor	Concrete Anchor
1	No discernible form	Music continues without any section divisions, repetition, or structural logic. No sense of where the piece is going.
2	Some section contrast, no jazz form	Verse/chorus-like contrast but not a jazz form. Doesn't cycle. No clear head or out-head.
3	Approximate jazz form	Something like AABA or 12-bar blues is audible but doesn't execute cleanly — chord changes happen in the wrong bar, sections are inconsistent lengths.
4	Correct form with minor inconsistencies	Recognisable jazz form that mostly works. Head stated, solos over the changes, head returns. One section miscounted or slightly misaligned.
5	Idiomatic form executed cleanly	Distinct head, improvised choruses over correct changes (correct bar count), out-head, possibly a tag or ritardando ending. A jazz musician would recognise the form immediately and be able to sit in.